



BIRLA INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY AND SCIENCE, Pilani
Pilani Campus
AUGS/ AGSR Division

FIRST SEMESTER 2026-27
COURSE HANDOUT

Date: 31.07.2026

In addition to part I (General Handout for all courses appended to the Time table) this portion gives further specific details regarding the course.

Course No : HSSF324
Course Title : SCIENCE FICTION
Instructor-in-Charge : Susan Haris (susan.haris@pilani.bits-pilani.ac.in)

1. Course Description: Key concepts and histories of science fiction; major theoretical frameworks in SF; utopias, dystopias, and speculative futures; science fiction in relation to technological and ecological change; feminist, postcolonial, and global interventions in SF; engagements with artificial intelligence, posthumanism, and the animal; and the reimagining of cultural and ecological futures through speculative storytelling.

2. Scope and Objective of the Course:

- i) Introduce students to science fiction as a literary mode that critiques technological and social change.
- ii) Explore how science fiction engages with questions of environment and the posthuman through narrative.
- iii) Examine connections between science, technology, and ethics through speculative imagination.
- iv) Develop interdisciplinary skills by linking literary analysis with perspectives from history of science and cultural studies.

3. Text Books: TB 1. Sherryl Vint. Science Fiction. MIT Press Essential Knowledge Series. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2021.

TB 2. Edward James and Farah Mendlesohn. The Cambridge Companion to Science Fiction, 2015.

TB 3. Darko Suvin. Metamorphoses of Science Fiction. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1979.

TB 4. Istvan Csicsery-Ronay Jr. The Seven Beauties of Science Fiction. Wesleyan University Press, 2008.

TB 5. Tarun K. Saint, ed. The Gollancz Book of South Asian Science Fiction, Vol. 1. Hachette India, 2019.

Reference Books:

R-1. *The New Routledge Companion to Science Fiction*. Edited By Mark Bould, Andrew M. Butler, Sherryl Vint, 2024.

R-2. Ted Chiang. *The Lifecycle of Software Objects*. Subterranean Press, 2010.

R-3. Arthur C. Clarke. *The Nine Billion Names of God: The Best Short Stories of Arthur C. Clarke*. Harcourt, 1967.

R-4. Ray Bradbury. *The Martian Chronicles*. New York: Doubleday, 1950.

R-5. Ursula K. Le Guin. *The Wind's Twelve Quarters*. Harper & Row, 1975.

R-6. Isaac Asimov. "The Last Question." *Science Fiction Quarterly*, 1956.

R-8. Vandana Singh. *The Woman Who Thought She Was a Planet and Other Stories*. New Delhi: Zubaan, 2008.

R-9. Nnedi Okorafor. *Kabu Kabu*. Prime Books, 2013.

R-10. Octavia Butler. *Bloodchild and Other Stories*. New York: Seven Stories Press, 2005.

R-11. Donna Haraway. *Manifestly Haraway*. University of Minnesota Press, 2016.



4. Course Plan:

Lecture No.	Learning objectives	Topics to be covered	Chapter in the Text Book
1-3	Introduce SF as a genre; origins and definitions	<i>STORY</i> What is Science Fiction? Definitions; sense of wonder; science vs. imagination; SF's Golden Age. Arthur C. Clarke (<i>The Nine Billion Names of God</i>)	TB1 Ch. 1 TB 3 Section 1
4-6	Explore dystopian imagination	<i>STORY</i> Environmental collapse; ethics of survival; concept of utopia and dystopia. Ray Bradbury (<i>There Will Come Soft Rains</i>)	TB 1 Ch. 2 TB 3 Section 1, TB 2, Ch 16.
7-9	Analyze dystopias in film; compare literary and cinematic dystopias	<i>MOVIE</i> Anime and Apocalypse; nuclear anxiety; technology and the city. Screening & discussion: <i>Akira</i> (1988)	TB 3 Section 1
10-12	Engage with Feminism and SF	<i>STORY</i> Feminist SF; reproduction and body politics; invisibility and gendered futures. Octavia Butler (<i>Bloodchild</i>)	TB 1 Ch.5, TB 2, Ch. 8
13-18	Study postcolonial/global SF traditions	<i>STORY</i> Science, empire, urban ecologies and local imaginaries. Vandana Singh (<i>Delhi</i>), Nnedi Okorafor (<i>Spider the Artist</i>)	TB 1 Ch.4, TB 5 Introduction
19-20	Examine Africanfuturism and global traditions	Futurity and cultural resistance. Comparative analysis: Singh, Okorafor	R1 Ch. 11
21-22	Explore philosophical SF in film	<i>MOVIE</i> Metaphysical SF; memory, grief, and the alien. Tarkovsky's <i>Solaris</i> (screening & discussion)	TB 1 Ch. 5, R1 Ch. 14
23-25	Discuss AI and posthumanism	<i>STORY</i> AI and autonomy; consciousness and ethics; digital life as species-being. Ted Chiang (<i>The Lifecycle of Software Objects</i>)	TB 1 Ch. 5, TB 2 Ch. 9
26- 28	Compare AI in literature and film	<i>MOVIE</i> Human vs. alien communication. <i>Arrival</i> (screening & discussion)	TB 1 Ch. 5



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29-31	Examine AI, language & the question of the animal	Nonhuman communication; animality and AI; embodiment vs. code. Arrival + Chiang	TB 1 Ch. 5, R1 Ch. 21, Ch. 29
32-34	Review dystopian & feminist themes across texts	<i>STORY</i> Ethics of sacrifice; gender and power; comparative utopias. Ursula Le Guin (<i>The Ones who walk away from Omelas</i>)	TB 1 Ch. 9
35-37	Understand theoretical frameworks of SF	Theory of estrangement; seven beauties of SF; SF as critical method. Csicsery-Ronay (<i>Seven Beauties</i>)	TB4 Ch. 1, Ch. 3.
38-40	Discuss Anthropocene and futures	Political ecology of sci-fi; cyborgs and justice Haraway (<i>Cyborg Manifesto</i>)	TB 1 Ch. 7, R 11
41-42	Usefulness of Science fiction & reflection	<i>STORY</i> Futures of SF; SF as cultural critique; Presentations, Asimov (<i>The Last Question</i>).	TB 4 Ch.3

6. Evaluation Scheme:

Component	Duration	Weightage (%)	Date & Time	Nature of component (Close Book/ Open Book)
Mid-Semester Test	90 Min.	25	07/10 AN1	Open book
Comprehensive Examination	3 h	35	10/12 FN	Open book
Assignment 1 Sci-Fi world building		30		Google doc
Assignment 2 Preposterous Technology		10		Presentation

7. Chamber Consultation Hour: 6170 B, 11-12 am Monday.

8. Notices: All the readings and announcements will be posted on Google classroom

9. Make-up Policy: Will be allowed if there is a genuine reason and the student reaches out to me promptly.

10. Attendance Policy: Class participation is essential to enjoy the readings.

11. Minimum passing Marks criteria:

12. Note (if any):

Instructor-in-charge Susan Haris
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